

Compliance-Grade Citation Standard

How Law Can You Go — v1.0 (locked 25 Aug 2026)

This document is the single source of truth for every legal citation in the catalog. It is not optional. It is the product, the moat, and the only path to B2B licensing revenue.

Entry-Level Frontmatter (required)

Field	Type	Description
id	string	Stable identifier. Never change after publish. Format: {category-prefix}-{nnn}
category	string	Topical bucket: Police Encounters, Traffic, Property, Debunk, etc.
topic	string	Human-readable headline. One sentence, no clickbait.
verdict	enum	settled varies debunked misrepresented unclear
states	string[]	Array of affected jurisdiction codes. Use USPS abbreviations or UK / US / EU.
last_verified	ISO date	Date the <i>entire entry</i> was last reviewed end-to-end.
risk_level	enum	low medium high critical
jurisdiction_required	boolean	Does the answer change by state?
receipts	object[]	Array of compliance-grade citations (see below). Minimum 1.

Receipt Schema (required — every receipt must have every field)

Field	Type	Description
instrument	string	Canonical short name of the legal instrument. e.g. <i>Brendlin v. California</i> or RCW 46.61.024
citation	string	Full formal citation string. Bluebook or ALWD format acceptable, but be consistent.
url	string	Live, direct link to the instrument. No paywall proxies. If the canonical source is PDF, link the PDF.
type	enum	case statute regulation report constitutional treaty
quote	string	Verbatim excerpt. No paraphrasing. Ellipses in square brackets [...] only.
offset	string	Character offset or section/paragraph reference that anchors the quote. e.g. p. 251, lines 8-12 or Sec. 123(a)(2)

Table 2 – continued

Field	Type	Description
repeal_checked	ISO date	Date when repeal / amendment / sunset status was verified.
repeal_status	enum	active repealed amended superseded uncertain
verdict	enum	What this instrument proves <i>relative to the entry's claim</i> : supports contradicts qualifies silent
review_date	ISO date	Date when this specific receipt was last reviewed.
source_verified	boolean	Was the source read directly (statute database, court opinion PDF), not via secondary summary?
notes	string	Optional. Analyst notes on weight, circuit split, known controversy, or why <i>uncertain</i> was chosen.

Rules

1. **No empty quotes.** An empty `quote` field is a compliance failure. If you cannot locate the verbatim text, do not publish the receipt.
2. **No dead links.** Every `url` must be tested before commit. If a link rots, the receipt must be updated or removed.
3. **Offset is not optional.** If you are citing a statute, the offset is the section and subsection. If you are citing a case, the offset is the page and line or paragraph number from the slip opinion.
4. **Repeal check is not optional.** Every statute must be checked against the current code. Every case must be checked for superseding decisions.
5. **Verdict per receipt.** The entry has a verdict. Each receipt also has a verdict saying what that instrument does for the claim.
6. **Review date per receipt.** Do not inherit `last_verified` from the entry. Each receipt is reviewed on its own cycle.
7. **Source verified.** If you read the statute on Justia instead of the official state code, mark `source_verified: false` and note it. This is honest, not shameful. But the goal is `true`.

Negative Findings

When the research finds that a statute does *not* exist, the receipt must still be structured:

```
- instrument: "Negative finding — federal eluding statute"
  citation: "No federal statute found"
  url: "https://uscode.house.gov/"
  type: "statute"
  quote: ""
  offset: "N/A"
  repeal_checked: "2026-08-25"
  repeal_status: "uncertain"
  verdict: "silent"
  review_date: "2026-08-25"
  source_verified: true
```

```
notes: "Searched US Code Title 18 and Title 49. No federal statute creates a right to continue driving  
↳ to a lit area before stopping for police."
```

The **quote** may be empty for a negative finding **only** if the **notes** field documents the search methodology and scope. Otherwise, rule 1 applies.

Template Lock

The template at `src/content/templates/entry-template.md` is locked. Any change to the template requires a PR and a version bump to this document.